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Brown Theology as Public Theology: César Chávez, the Sanctuary Movement, and Latinx Theology

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ABSTRACT

This essay explores the critical reflection and social impact of Latinx public theologians and introduces the concept of Brown Theology. Brown Theology may be defined as the little known, 500-year Latinx tradition of social justice theology. With its methodological emphasis upon praxis and social change, I argue that Brown Theology is inherently a form of public theology. As an underexplored epistemology with strong connections to grassroots Latinx communities, Brown Theology has much potential to serve as a synergistic intellectual partner for LatCrit and the broader field of Critical Race Theory. Brown Theology complements Chicanx/Latinx Studies and Critical Race Theory in so far as it unearths the religious assumptions which gave rise to legal conceptions of race in the U.S. and Latin America, and replaces them with liberatory theologies which are relatable to grassroots Latinx communities for whom Christian spirituality remains central.

KEYWORDS

Liberation theology; public theology; Cesar Chavez; Chicanx Studies; Latinx Studies; Critical Race Theory; Lat Crit

Introduction

Public theology involves theological discourse on public issues.[1] Though developed historically within a Christian theological context, public theology supports pluralistic religious discourse fostering democratic values such as racial equality, tolerance, and human rights.[2] As reflected in his usage of theological concepts such as the beloved community, the image of God, spiritual slavery, and the city of God, Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. is regarded as a worldwide exemplar of public theology and social activism.[3] Other often-cited public theologians include figures such as Dietrich Bonhoeffer, Desmond Tutu, Jürgen Moltmann, and Reinhold Niebuhr. Although numerous Latinx[4] public

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[1]Kim and Day, *A Companion to Public Theology*, 4.

[2]Lee, "Public Theology," 44.

[3]Stackhouse, "Civil Religion, Political Theology and Public Theology," 79–95, 87.

[4]The terms Latinx, Latina/o, and Latine are hotly contested terms of identity. In general, Latino refers to an individual of Latin American heritage, whose parentage descends from any one of the 33 countries comprising Latin America. A Latina is a person who identifies as a female person of Latin American heritage. Latinx emerged as a term of gender inclusivity in the U.S. context, to encompass all those of Latin American descent, regardless of gender identity,

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theologians have promoted widescale social change in Latin America and the United States over the past century, Latinxs have unfortunately been excluded from scholarly discourse on the topic.

This essay explores the critical reflection and social impact of Latinx public theologians and introduces the concept of Brown Theology. Brown Theology may be defined as the little known, 500-year Latinx tradition of social justice theology.[5] The phrase "Brown Theology" serves as a metaphor. Brown is a metaphor for the rich ethnic and racial diversity of Latin America – including those of diverse indigenous, African, European, Jewish, Middle Eastern, and Asian heritages. In the U.S. context, Brown serves as a metaphor for the racial liminality experienced by Latinos as betwixt and between that of Black and White. With its methodological emphasis upon praxis and social change, I argue that Brown Theology is inherently a form of public theology. As a form of public theological discourse, Brown Theology has played an important role in supporting major civil rights victories of both the farmworker and Sanctuary movements. As an underexplored epistemology with strong connections to grassroots Latinx communities, Brown Theology has much potential to serve as a synergistic intellectual partner for Chicanx/Latinx Studies, Critical Race Theory (CRT), and Latinx Critical Race Theory (LatCrit). Brown Theology complements Chicanx/Latinx Studies and Critical Race Theory in so far as it unearths the religious assumptions which gave rise to legal conceptions of race in the U.S. and Latin America, and replaces them with liberatory theologies which are relatable to grassroots Latinx communities for whom Christian spirituality remains central. As a form of public theology, Brown Theology may also be utilized for the practical purpose of promoting conscientization, community organizing, and social engagement. This essay shall build this argument drawing from the case studies of César Chávez, the Sanctuary Movement, and Latinx Theology.

The spiritual formation of César Chávez

For both Martin Luther King, Jr. and César Chávez, their early Christian spiritualities were shaped primarily by their families and the popular cultures and religions in which they were raised. King's family, church, and southern upbringing formed the basis for his Christian spirituality.[6] His grandmother, in particular, played a critical role in both his religious and emotional formation.[7] According to King, she was "a saintly grandmother," and "a strong spiritual force, a bearer of culture, and a pillar of strength" for the King family. King learned about the intersection of faith and social justice, or, "political-prophetic spirituality," from his family, church, and local community.[8] From "Daddy King," Martin came to understand Christian ministry as a vehicle for social change.[9]

and also in support of those with gender fluid identities. Latinx is used mostly in academic and activist settings, and much less among grassroots immigrant communities in the U.S. Because the usage of "x" is inconsistent with traditional Spanish rules of grammar, some have shifted to the use of, "Latine." Latine connotes a similar sense of gender inclusivity, but is more consistent with formal Latin American grammar. Given the mostly U.S., academic audience of this essay, I have opted to use the term "Latinx" in most instances.

[5]To be clear, I use the term Brown Theology to refer to the broad and diverse tradition of Latinx social justice theology, but not as a synonym for all theology written by all persons of Latino background on all topics.

[6]Lee, *We Will Get*, 49.

[7]Ibid., 52.

[8]Ibid., 58.

[9]Ibid., 59–60.

Similar to that of King, Chávez' early spirituality was shaped by his family and grounded in "abuelita theology," or, "grandmother theology."[10] Because formal religious instruction and seminary education is often less accessible to Latinx families, the best theologians of the Latinx community are often grandmothers, or, "abuelitas."[11] According to Virgilio Elizondo, "Our abuelitas [grandmothers], viejitas [older women], and madrecitas[mothers] have been the functional priestesses and theologians of our iglesia del pueblo [church of the people]."[12] Consistent with this common pattern, Chávez learned about Mexican popular Catholicism from his "abuelita," "Mama Tella," who introduced him to prayer and the Christian faith:

> Mama Tella [grandmother] gave us our formal religious training … [S]he was always praying, just praying. Every evening she would sit in bed, and we would gather in front of her. … After the Rosary she would tell us about a particular saint and drill us on our Catechism.[13]

From his mother, Chávez learned the biblical value of loving the poor:

> [M]y mother would tell us, 'You always have to help the needy, and God will help you.[14]

Also similar to King, Chávez later expanded his spiritual formation through the influence of liberal white clergy. Although the Black Church formed the basis for King's spirituality and ministry, his understanding of race, social justice, and theology was further honed as part of graduate studies at the liberal white institutions of Crozer Theological Seminary and Boston University.[15] While at Crozer and Boston University, King gained exposure to progressive theologians such as Paul Tillich, Walter Rauschenbusch, and Reinhold Niebuhr, and consequently he developed the theological concepts which would later serve as the foundation for the black civil rights movement.[16]

Unlike King, Chávez did not expand his theological understanding through a process of formal seminary education. In fact, after completing the 8th grade he dropped out of school in order to work in agriculture.[17] Chávez' introduction to the theology of social justice began much later in 1952 under the mentorship of white Roman Catholic clergyman Father Donald McDonnell. The two met at a church in the barrio of Sal Si Puedes in San Jose, where Chávez was also introduced to Dolores Huerta.[18] Seeing his leadership potential, McDonnell mentored Chávez and introduced him to labor history, community organizing, and the social teachings of the Catholic church.[19] In the words of Chávez:

> I began to spend a lot of time with Father McDonnell. We had long talks about farm workers. I knew a lot about the work, but I didn't know anything about the economics … And then we did a lot of reading. That's when I started reading the Encyclicals, St. Francis, and Gandhi and having the case for attaining social justice explained.[20]

[10]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 5–6.
[11]Dalton, *The Moral Vision*, 33–34.
[12]Ibid., 34.
[13]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 26–27.
[14]Ibid., 26.
[15]Lee, *We Will Get*, 65.
[16]Ibid., 66.
[17]Del Castillo and Garcia, *Cesar Chavez*, 12.
[18]Dalton, *The Moral Vision*, 49.
[19]Ibid., 48.
[20]Ibid., 48.

United farm workers: fusion of Abuelita theology, Catholic social teachings, and Alinsky organizing methods

As is more well known among ethnic studies scholars, following his formative training with Father McDonnell, Chávez went to work as a community organizer with the Community Service Organization (CSO).[21] After serving for ten years as a community organizer and national director of the CSO,[22] Chávez branched out on his own to form the National Farm Workers Association (NFWA) in the San Joaquin Valley.[23] In 1965, the fledgling organization was asked by a smaller union of Filipino agricultural workers to participate in a strike against the major grape growers of the Central Valley. On Mexican Independence Day, September 16, 1965, Chávez and the NFWA joined the strike. Lasting five years, the strike gave birth to the United Farm Workers and catapulted Chávez into international acclaim. In a strange twist of irony, Chávez did not even start the very strike which made him famous. The uniqueness of Chávez' approach lay in his fusion of popular Mexican religious symbols and practices, Catholic social teaching, and Alinsky-based organizing strategies which he learned while at the CSO. The centrality of religion in the activism of César Chávez and the UFW is often glossed over by labor historians and the fields of Chicanx and Latinx Studies. Speaking of the importance of his Catholic faith, Chávez once declared, "Today I don't think I could base my will to struggle on cold economics or on some political doctrine. I don't think there would be enough to sustain me. For me, the base must be faith."[24]

As a public theologian, Chávez drew from the rich well of popular Mexican Catholicism to lend spiritual power and meaning to the farm worker movement. Although he did not publish formal theological treatises, his famous marches and acts of fasting communicated deep theological convictions and have been called "liturgies of protest." In spring of 1966, Chávez fashioned his famous march from the Central Valley to Sacramento as a penitential pilgrimage, or "peregrinacion."[25] Drawing from popular Mexican religious tradition, he called the march, "Penitence, Pilgrimage, and Revolution."[26] Chávez viewed the Sacramento march as a means of spiritual purification and seeking the favor of God:

> But throughout the Spanish speaking world there is another Tradition that touches the present march, that of the Lenten penitential processions, where the penitentes would march through the streets, often in sack cloth and ashes, some even carrying crosses as a sign of penance for their sins, and as a plea for the mercy of God. The penitential procession is also in the blood of the Mexican-American, and the Delano march will therefore be one of penance—public penance for the sins of the strikers, their own personal sins as well their yielding perhaps to feelings of hatred and revenge in the strike itself. They hope by the march to set themselves at peace with the Lord, so that the justice of their cause will be purified of all lesser motivation.[27]

In further religious significance, the penitential pilgrimage was led by a priest in full clerical garb together with a banner of the Virgin of Guadalupe.[28] Chávez and his

[21]Garcia, *The Gospel,* 9.
[22]Dalton, *The Moral Vision*, 7.
[23]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 11; Dalton, *The Moral Vision*, 8.
[24]Levy, *César Chávez*, 27.
[25]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 12.
[26]Ibid., 16.
[27]León, *The Political Spirituality*, 22.
[28]Ibid., 24.

followers arrived in Sacramento on Easter and concluded their pilgrimage with the celebration of mass.[29]

Chavez' famous fast of 1968 was also imbued with deep religious significance aimed at reinforcing the UFW commitment to nonviolence. Bringing crucifixes and altars to La Virgen de Guadalupe, thousands of farmworkers visited Chávez to support his fast at the Forty Acres headquarters in Delano, and even established a tent city.[30] Chávez and his many supporters celebrated mass together daily with union wine and tortillas administered by priests wearing vestments made of union flags.

Chávez viewed fasting as a spiritual exercise, as opposed to a "hunger strike" aimed at accomplishing a political goal or forcing his adversaries to submit to his demands.[31] Through fasting, Chávez sought to draw near to God through prayer, and each day he celebrated mass and received la "santa cena" (communion). Speaking of the spiritual basis of his 1968 fast, he stated:

> My fast is informed by my religious faith and by my deep roots in the Church. It is not intended as pressure on anyone but only is an expression of my own deep feelings and my own need to do penance and to be in prayer.[32]

> I pray to God that this fast will be a preparation for a multiple of simple deeds of justice, carried out by men and women whose hearts are focused on the suffering of the poor and who yearn, with us, for a better world.[33]

Many in the movement criticized Chávez for his fasting, calling him overly spiritual.[34] They mused that the UFW needed him to act publicly and decisively, not shut the movement down with religious activities. Undeterred, Chávez viewed prayer and fasting as the keys to the success of the grape strike and the larger farm worker struggle. According to Dolores Huerta:

> I know it's hard for people who are not Mexican to understand, but this is part of the Mexican culture—the penance, the whole idea of suffering for something, of self-inflicted punishment. It's a tradition of very long standing. In fact, César has often mentioned in speeches that we will not win through violence, we will win through fasting and prayer.[35]

In the end, beyond its spiritual significance, the fast proved wildly successful in furthering the aims of the UFW. It became a hinge point of the movement, and, in the words of one observer: "The irony of the fast was that it turned out to be the greatest organizing tool in the history of the labor movement."[36] As a consequence of the fast, the use of violence ceased, dedication increased among union supporters, and the grape boycott expanded internationally.[37] Taking place at the height of the civil rights movement, the 1968 fast garnered wide national attention. Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. sent a telegram of

[29]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 95.
[30]Levy, *Cesar Chavez*, 275.
[31]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 103.
[32]Ibid., 110.
[33]Ibid., 104.
[34]Levy, Cesar Chavez, 277.
[35]Ibid., 277.
[36]Ibid., 95.
[37]Levy, *César Chávez*, 275; Bruns, *César*, xiii; La Botz, *César Chávez*, 94.

support and Chávez broke his fast with the celebration of mass on the back of a farmworker truck with Senator Robert Kennedy.[38]

Like King, Chávez's firm commitment to nonviolence flowed centrally from his Christian convictions. These convictions were shaped by several sources, including the "abuelita theology" of his youth, Catholic social teachings, and the historical examples of St. Francis of Assisi, Gandhi, and Martin Luther King, Jr.[39] In response to his critics, Chávez emphasized the active nature of nonviolent direct action. Nonviolence did not equate to passivity, but incorporated the use of peaceful, strategic methods such as boycotts, strikes, pilgrimages, prayer, and fasting. Chávez called his approach "militant nonviolence" and Gandhian "moral jujitsu."[40] According to Chávez, nonviolence was more effective than violence because, on a practical level the growers wielded superior physical power in the form of local police. The farmworkers would always lose a head-to-head violent confrontation.

Chávez's mother communicated to him the wisdom of nonviolence through dichos, or Mexican folk sayings. She challenged the deeply ingrained machismo of Mexican culture which fostered violent retaliation, and cited the teachings of Jesus: "No, it's best to turn the other cheek. God gave you senses like eyes and mind and tongue and you can get out of anything. It takes two to fight and one can't do it alone".[41]

Chávez also drew inspiration for nonviolent direct action from biblical history, the early church, and Gandhi:

> Some great nonviolent successes have been achieved in history. Moses is about the best example, and the first one. Christ is also a beautiful example, as is the way Christians overcame tyranny. They needed over three hundred years, but they did it. The most recent example is Gandhi. To me that's the most beautiful one. We can examine it more closely because it happened during our lifetime.[42]

In sum, in so far as he infused popular cultural and religious practices into the farmworker movement, César Chávez followed in the steps of Martin Luther King, Jr. as a public theologian. In his own unique way, however, Chávez brought together "abuelita theology," Catholic social teachings, and Alinsky organizing methods into an untraditional mixture which promoted broad mass appeal on both a national and international level. Though sometimes expressed through direct theological proclamation, the public theology of Chávez most often expressed itself through "liturgies of protest" which took the forms of pilgrimage, fasting, and nonviolent direct action accompanied by religious symbols. This approach was wildly successful, at least during the first decade of the UFW movement, and led to the creation of a broad interreligious coalition of supporters. This coalition which corresponded with the dominant religious communities of the time, including Protestants, Pentecostals, Roman Catholics, and Jews. Ultimately, Chávez' distinct public theology approach led to the first successful unionization of farmworkers in U.S. history.[43]

[38]Del Castillo and Garcia, *César Chávez*, 86; La Botz, *César Chávez*, 95.
[39]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 63–64; Orosco, *César Chávez*, 24.
[40]Garcia, *The Gospel*, 63–65.
[41]Orosco, *César Chávez and the Common Sense of Nonviolence*, 24.
[42]Levy, *César Chávez*, 27–271.
[43]Despite his many successes, like many civil rights icons before and after, Chávez had moral failures, including his harsh rhetoric towards undocumented immigrants. For more on the decline and fall of Chávez following the movement's crescendo in 1975, see, Romero, *Brown Church*, chapter 5.

The Brown Church and Brown Theology

Chávez is perhaps the most famous figure in modern times of what may be called the Brown Church. The Brown Church may be defined as: a prophetic ecclesial community of Latinas/os that has contested racial and social injustice in Latin America and the United States for the past five hundred years. Brown Church is a multivalent category, encompassing ethnic, historical, theological, spiritual, and sociopolitical dimensions.[44] I use the term "brown" as a symbol of the diverse cultural and biological mestizaje, or, mixture, in Latin America which includes those of indigenous, African, European, and even Asian descent. I do not mean brown in a literal, phenotypical sense, for those of Latin American ancestry hail from diverse ethnic and national experiences and reflect a broad phenotypical range which reflects the diversity of the world. Some, like myself, are literally brown, but we Latinxs come in all colors and hues – some are moreno[dark complected], some are güeritos [fair skinned], some are subtle in between shades, and quite a few, like myself, are even Asian. In this sense, brown is symbolic of the unique cultural and biological mestizaje, or, mixture, which is to be found in Latin America.[45]

In the US context, I use the term brown as a metaphor to represent the historic racial positioning of Latinxs between that of "white" and "black." Since the U.S.-Mexico War and the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo in 1848, Mexican Americans, and by extension, other Latinxs, have shared a liminal racial positioning as legally, socially, and politically "in between" black and white.[46] As a metaphor for racial, cultural, and social liminality, brown is a fluid "space" as opposed to any body of static, essentialized cultural characteristics.[47] In this sense, brown can be an appropriate term to express the racial "in-betweenness" of other cultural groups in the United States such as Asian Americans, Middle Easterners, and those of the fast-growing mixed race community.

As a natural outgrowth of its prophetic advocacy efforts and praxis, the Brown Church has developed a unique and consistent body of social justice theology based upon the Christian Scriptures. Unbeknownst to most within Latinx Studies and Critical Race Theory (CRT), there is a five-hundred-year history of Latinx theologians who have spoken and written about issues of race and social justice from a liberatory perspective. They have been Protestant and Catholic, men and women, and from both Latin America and the United States. In every instance of racial and social injustice in Latin America and the United States over the centuries, Latinx theologians and church leaders have arisen to

[44]Romero, *Brown Church*, 11.

[45]To be clear, in utilizing the term mestizaje, I do not mean the socio-political project of mestizaje which dates back to the Mexican Revolution and elevates an historic and romantic view of indigenous communities while at the same time promoting the erasure of diverse, living, breathing indigenous communities. Rather, I use the metaphor of mestizaje following in the theological footsteps of Justo Gonzalez, Virgilio Elizondo, Maria Pilar Aquino, Ada Maria Isasi-Díaz, Arturo Bañuelas, Eldin Villafañe, Loida I. Martell-Otero, Nestor Medina, and others.

[46]It is important to recognize the significant limits of the metaphor of brown. In using this metaphor for the U.S. context, it is not my intent to romanticize a shared "Brownness," or to elide questions of racial difference within the culturally, ethnically, and nationally diverse Latinx community. Rather, I use brown as a symbol of a shared liminal historical social, legal, and political positioning of Latinos in the U.S. For more on the historical, social and legal construction of Latinos as a liminal racial group in the United States, see, Laura Gomez, *Inventing Latinos: A New Story of American Racism* (New York City: The New Press: 2020). For further reading on how Latinx and Latin American theologians are in fact theorizing their lived experiences in complex and contradictory ways because of their various positionalities, see: Márquez's, *Making the Latino South*, as well as the writings of Alan Pelaez and Lorgia García-Peña.

[47]Ibid., 13–14.

challenge the religious, socio-economic, and political status quo. Collectively, they have challenged such great evils as the Spanish Conquest and colonialism, the sistema de castas, Manifest Destiny, Latin American dictatorships, US imperialism in Central America, the oppression of farmworkers, and the current exploitation and marginalization of undocumented immigrants. In addition to César Chávez, other notable figures of the Brown Church include Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz, Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala, Garcilaso de la Vega el Inca, Padre Antonio Martinez, Dolores Huerta, Archbishop Oscar Romero, Father Luis Olivares, Gustavo Gutierrez, Rene Padilla, Samuel Escobar, Justo Gonzalez, Ada Maria Isasi-Diaz, and Elizabeth Conde-Frazier.[48] As a natural outgrowth of their prophetic advocacy efforts and praxis, these theologians have developed a communal body of liberatory theology that may collectively be called Brown Theology.[49] Quite notably, in the U.S. context, Brown Theology shares many of the same racial justice themes of Chicanx/Latinx Studies, CRT, and LatCrit related to identity, mestizaje, colonialism, gender, and immigration. Ironically, U.S. Brown Theology has developed side by side historically with these "secular" fields but has held little academic conversation.

Father Luis Olivares and the Sanctuary Movement

Inspired by the U.S.-based social justice efforts of César Chávez, as well as the Latin American liberation theology movement, the Sanctuary Movement of the 1980s provides another poignant example of the contemporary Brown Church which is often overlooked by scholars of Ethnic Studies and Critical Race Theory. Hilary Cunningham has defined the Sanctuary Movement thusly:

> This movement can be defined as a religiopolitical coalition that began as a network of churches and synagogues that decided to offer "safe haven" or "sanctuary" to Central American fugitives denied political asylum by the U.S. Immigration and Naturalization Service (INS) … at its height in 1986–1987 it spanned Mexico, the United States, and Canada, included more than four hundred religious congregations, and claimed between sixty and seventy thousands participants.[50]

Although valuable studies of the Sanctuary Movement have been produced over the years, one critique is that they in general overlook the agency of Central American migrants and the role which U.S. Latino Christians played in the movement. As Lloyd Barba and Tatyana Castillo-Ramos have argued, however, Latina/o leadership in the original sanctuary movement was actually robust and widespread.[51] Latinx leaders exercised active agency, but often chose to remain out of the limelight as a deliberate strategy in order to avoid arrest and deportation. Inspired by the faith-based activism of César Chávez and Latin American liberation theology, Father Luis Olivares and the Los Angeles-based Sanctuary Movement offer another compelling example of the Brown Church, Brown Theology, and Latino public theology.

Under the leadership of Claretian priest, Luis Olivares, the Brown Church played a focal role in the development of the Sanctuary Movement in Los Angeles.[52] Similar to

[48]Ibid., 11.
[49]Ibid., 11–12.
[50]Cunningham, *God and Caesar*, 13.
[51]Barba and Castillo-Ramos, "Latinx Leadership and Legacies," 1–24, 5.
[52]Garcia, *Father Luis*, 11.

Chávez, Father Olivares was born into a deeply religious Mexican Catholic family which emphasized justice and care for the poor.[53] As residents of the Mexican barrio of San Antonio, Texas, the Olivares family ran an "underground railroad" which protected Mexican priests from persecution as part of the Cristero War in of the 1920s.[54] Also like Chavez, Luis' young faith was shaped by his own abuelita, Inecita, who took him to daily morning mass at 6:15 am and guided him in the recitation of the rosary every evening.[55] Inecita's spiritual commitment also led her to invite the less fortunate to meals of coffee and tortillas in her home, and also to supply them clothing. All of this had a deep impact upon Luis, as recounted by one of his sisters:

> I think that the seed that Louie got … was that my grandmother was always helping people. Anybody that would knock at the door would not leave without eating. If they didn't have a place to sleep, they would find a place at the house. Our house was always packed.[56]

Luis, or Louie as his family called him, discerned his religious calling at a young age and began his studies at the Claretian junior seminary in Compton, California at the age of 13. Beginning with this early seminary education, Luis trained for 13 years before being ordained a priest in 1961 in the San Fernando Cathedral of San Antonio. He also went on to receive a master's degree in financial administration from the prestigious University of Notre Dame in 1965. After his ordination, Olivares ministered as a priest in the Claretian order, and from 1967–1977 served as treasurer of the western branch of the Claretians. In this role, he was responsible for investing and growing the funds of the religious order. Although he possessed a concern for the poor during these years, his passion for social justice did not emerge until the mid-1970s under the inspiration of César Chávez and the farmworkers movement. Like his contemporary Archbishop Oscar Romero, and Bartolomé de las Casas centuries earlier, Father Luis had a "second conversion" to the poor and marginalized.[57]

His conscientization was shaped in large measure by the influence of then Claretian seminary student, Richard Estrada. Eager to participate in the second grape boycott in East Los Angeles in 1974, Richard required a priest-sponsor to oversee his ministry activities.[58] Olivares volunteered for this role, and through this sponsorship became introduced to César Chávez, Dolores Huerta, and the farmworkers struggle. The farmworkers movement reshaped his view of ministry and the Gospel:

> I live a double standard as a cleric and I guess, as a Mexican American. One of the greatest things that has happened to me, as to my involvement with the United Farm Workers, is an awareness as to where life really is. The things that are of value to farmworkers give you a totally different perspective. You start seeing the dimensions of the gospel. [It has had] a tremendous influence on me.[59]

Like Moses whose eyes were open after wandering from the security of opulent Egyptian society to see the suffering of his own people in Goshen, so, too did Father Luis

[53]Ibid., 12; Garcia, *Católicos*, 213, 215.
[54]Garcia, *Father Luis*, 12,37; Garcia, *Católicos*, 213.
[55]Ibid., 215.
[56]Ibid., 215.
[57]Garcia, *Católicos*, 216–217; Garcia, *Father Luis*, 12.
[58]Garcia, *Católicos*, 217.
[59]Ibid., 217–218.

experience a "second conversion" to the poor after being exposed first-hand to the suffering of the farmworkers. Olivares became a priest of the Brown Church, and officiated UFW baptisms, funerals, and weddings. He became personal priest to Chávez, and Chávez reciprocally served as a spiritual director to Father Luis. After his conversion to the Brown Church, Father Luis in 1975 became priest of Our Lady of Solitude Church in Boyle Heights. As pastor of Our Lady of Solitude, Olivares became an activist priest and helped to launch the United Neighborhoods Organization, or, UNO. Together with other community leaders such as pastor Juan Romero, Lydia Lopez, and Ernie Cortés, UNO organized and advocated around issues such as high auto insurance rates, the quality of public school education, public health programs, and gang violence. Notably, UNO organized chapters through Catholic churches, and even with the Episcopal Church of the Epiphany in Lincoln Heights. As an important historic side note, the Church of the Epiphany, though Protestant, served as a Chicano religious hub, not only for UNO, but also for the Brown Berets and Católicos Por La Raza.[60]

It was as parish priest of La Placita Church across from downtown Olvera Street, that Father Olivares would go on to launch the Sanctuary Movement in Los Angeles in the 1980s. This historic church was founded in 1781 as the birthplace of the city of Los Angeles, and in the 1980s was flourishing with 11 Spanish-language masses which were attended by both Central American and Mexican immigrants. During that decade, Los Angeles grew as a center of Salvadoran migration, and soon became distinguished as the city with the second largest population of Salvadoreños outside of San Salvador.[61]

As the number of Central American refugees continued to increase in the La Placita congregation, Father Louie – as Olivares was affectionately known – together with Father Richard Estrada, Lydia Lopez, and Jesuit priest, Michael Kennedy, developed a ministry of sanctuary and holistic support. On December 12, 1985, the feast day of La Virgen de Guadalupe, La Placita was declared the first Catholic sanctuary church in Los Angeles. The pronouncement was made as part of a large public gathering featuring eighty religious leaders of various faiths, celebrities from film and television, and, most importantly, the Central American refugee community.[62] At the press conference which accompanied the event, Father Olivares proclaimed:

> Today, December 12, 1985, on the feast day of Our Lady of Guadalupe, the patroness of the Americas, we here at La Placita Church in unity with our brothers and sisters of other faiths publicly declare the church to be a sanctuary for refugees fleeing persecution and oppression in Central America. These Salvadorans and Guatemaltecos are our brothers and sisters also and we will not turn them away.[63]

As a sanctuary congregation, La Placita offered shelter for as many as 200 refugees each day. They slept on, and underneath church pews. Women and children were placed with Mexican American families and also at Blessed Sacrament Church in Hollywood. In addition to the provision of housing, Olivares, Lopez, and other pastoral staff provided food, transportation, clothing, English language instruction, and legal

[60]Garcia, *Father Luis*, 13,207,230; Garcia, *Católicos*, 218–219.
[61]Ibid., 220–221; Garcia, *Father Luis*, 11, 255.
[62]Garcia, *Father Luis*, 15, 322, 328, 329, 331, 226.
[63]Garcia, *Católicos*, 226.

assistance.[64] Employment was also secured through the broader sanctuary network in Los Angeles which included Jewish synagogues and mainline Protestant denominations. The Centro Pastoral Rutilio Grande, named after one of the first Salvadoran martyrs, was created to coordinate these various ministry efforts. Father Luis was also the first chairperson of the Coalition for Humane Immigrant Rights of Los Angeles (CHIRLA).[65]

As a public theologian, Father Olivares drew upon the influence of Latin American liberation theology, and especially the concept of the preferential option for the poor.[66] According to Peruvian theologian Gustavo Gutierrez, the preferential option for the poor stands for the proposition that God expresses unique concern for those who are socially and economically disenfranchized and takes the side of the poor in their oppression.[67] Gutierrez asserts, moreover, that this theme of God's unique concern for the poor is a consistent motif found throughout both the Old and New Testaments:

> The entire Bible, beginning with the story of Cain and Abel, mirrors God's predilection for the weak and abused of human history. This preference brings out the gratuitous or unmerited character of God's love. The same revelation is given in the evangelical Beatitudes, for they tell us with the utmost simplicity that God's predilection for the poor, the hungry, and the suffering is based on God's unmerited goodness to us.[68]

> God' preferential option for the poor, the weak, the least members of society runs throughout the Bible and cannot be understood apart from the absolute freedom and gratuitousness of God's love … For God, therefore, "the last will be first, and the first will be last." … God's love, and therefore what God demands of us, leaps over these boundaries and goes out in a free and generous search of those whom society marginalizes and oppresses. … Universality and preference mark the proclamation of the kingdom. God addresses a message of life to every human being without exception, while at the same time God shows preference for the poor and the oppressed.[69]

Inspired by the preferential option for the poor, Olivares did not shy away from political confrontation with governmental authorities who supported oppressive laws and policies, and he also critiqued the institutional church for its accommodation of the status quo.[70] Wherever human laws conflicted with God's moral law of justice, Christians held a moral responsibility to stand for God's laws.[71] In its concrete service of immigrants and the poor, Father Luis sought to return to the original roots of the Christian church as expressed by Jesus in his public proclamation in Luke 4: 18–19:

> The Spirit of the Lord is upon me,
> because he has anointed me
> to bring good news to the poor.
> He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives
> and recovery of sight to the blind,
> to let the oppressed go free,
> to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor.

[64]Ibid., 233.
[65]Ibid., 233, 249.
[66]Ibid., 14, 285–286.
[67]Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation*, 13.
[68]Ibid., xxvii.
[69]Gutiérrez, *The God of Life*, 116.
[70]Garcia, *Católicos*, 222.
[71]Ibid., 222, 225.

Beyond its prophetic religious nature, the Sanctuary Movement at La Placita was also notable for the way in which it articulated an early view of pan-Latino racial identity. Whereas the broader Chicano movement of the 1970s and 80's tended towards a "Mexican-centric" identity, Father Luis unified his congregants around a Catholic Latino identity which embraced Mexican, Guatemalan, Salvadoran, and other Latino national cultural groups.[72] The sanctuary movement in Los Angeles forged a pan-Latino identity out of practice and necessity. In order to remain faithful to its religious mission, the Placita church, an historic Mexican congregation, was required to expand its ecclesial imagination to embrace the thousands of new congregants coming from Central America. Through works of justice and the sanctuary movement, God was assembling a new "blessed community," and to fail to do so would be to deny God's work in their midst.[73] In the words of Father Luis: "It's gratifying to help. But more important is what has happened to our hearts and attitudes on Central America. Before we declared sanctuary, a lot of you thought that La Placita was here for Mexicans alone. But now you have learned that anyone in need is your neighbor."[74]

The legal advocacy efforts of Father Luis and the broader national Sanctuary Movement came to important fruition in the case of American Baptist Churches v. Thornburg Settlement Agreement (1991) and the passage of the Nicaraguan Adjustment and Central American Relief Act (NACARA)(1997).[75] The former settlement was the end result of a five-year federal lawsuit filed by a coalition of religious groups such as the American Baptist denomination, together with human rights organizations, including the National Lawyers Guild and the American Civil Liberties Union. In this lawsuit, plaintiffs asserted that migrants from Guatemala and El Salvador had been denied due process in their asylum petitions. To demonstrate their case, plaintiffs offered evidence that less than 1% of applicants from Guatemala, and 3% from El Salvador had been granted asylum in 1984. As a result of legal negotiation, the U.S. government agreed to review de novo, the asylum cases of hundreds of thousands of refugees from El Salvador and Guatemala. While waiting for their cases to be reviewed, hundreds of thousands of Central American refugees were granted temporary protection from deportation and work permits. In 1997, faced with a large back log of asylum cases from Central America, Congress, passed the Nicaraguan and Central American Relief Act. Building upon the earlier legal victory established by the ABC settlement agreement, this legislation granted legal permanent residency to hundreds of thousands of registered asylums seekers who had resided in the United States since at least December 1, 1990. Together, American Baptist Churches v. Thornburg and NACARA transformed the lives of thousands of Central American refugees, and as such represent two of the most important civil rights victories in modern times.

[72]Garcia, *Católicos*, 226–227.
[73]Ibid., 230.
[74]Ibid., 231.
[75]For an official government summary of the American Baptist Churches v. Thornburgh Settlement agreement, see https://www.uscis.gov/humanitarian/refugees-and-asylum/asylum/american-baptist-churches-v-thornburgh-abc-settlement-agreement (accessed July 8, 2023). For an overview of NACARA, see https://www.uscis.gov/humanitarian/refugees-and-asylum/asylum/nicaraguan-adjustment-and-central-american-relief-act-nacara-203-eligibility-to-apply-with-uscis (accessed July 8, 2023).

Latinx theology

The public theologizing of Father Olivares was part of the first wave of Brown Theology in the United States. Inspired by Latin American liberation theologies, the Chicano, Puerto Rican, and Black civil rights movements, and the growth of diverse Latinx communities in the United States, Latinxs began to self- theologize in the 1970s and 1980s.[76] Early U.S. Latinx theologians were both Protestant and Roman Catholic, and their goals were to develop theology from a distinct Latinx perspective and promote racial reforms within the institutions of U.S. Christianity. According to religion scholar Edwin Aponte, Latinx theology may be defined as:

> The distinct theologies that emerge out of the social and cultural contexts of Latino/a peoples, which, nonetheless, have some shared characteristics. These common traits make Latino/a theology a communal undertaking that is scholarly, pastoral, and organically connected to grassroots communities. Latino/a theology insists on doing theology in a relevant contextual way that is both in dialogue with the received dominant theological traditions as well as questioning of them and their claims of being standard.[77]

Over the past four decades, Latinx theology has emerged as a distinct field of theological reflection in the United States. Since it has developed historically side by side with the disciplines of Chicanx/Latinx Studies, Critical Race Theory, and LatCrit, Latinx theology not surprisingly shares common racial justice aims and explores similar themes related to racial identity, decolonialism, immigration, and gender. Like CRT, Latinx theology holds common conviction that racism is ordinary, a normal feature of US society, and that race and races are products of social thought and relations.[78] Latinx theology, however, attributes the social construction of race and its ordinariness to the theological concept of sin as the ultimate root cause. With LatCrit, Latinx theology shares commitments to intergroup justice, antisubordination, praxis/solidarity, and community building, but ultimately seeks the establishment of the Beloved Community of people from every tribe, language, nation, and tongue.[79]

With respect to racial identity, Latinx theology reflects upon the unique racial identity and positioning of the Latinx community within the white–black racial binary of the United States, but through a religious lens. Latinx theologians postulate diverse theologies of identity through the examination of themes such as marginality, poverty, mestizaje/mulatez, and exile.[80] Justo Gonzalez and Orlando Costas, on the Protestant side, and Virgilio Elizondo, on the Catholic side, signaled the birth of this field through the publication of their seminal works, Galilean Journey, Mañana, and Christ Outside the Gate. Elizabeth Conde-Frazier, Orlando Espin, Edwin Aponte, Ada Maria Isasi-Diaz, Eldin Villafane, Loida I. Martell-Otero, Miguel de la Torre, Juan Martinez, M. Daniel Carroll, and Oscar Garcia-Johnson, Jeanette Rodriguez, Maria Pilar Aquino, Daisy Machado, and Nestor Medina have developed the field over the past two decades into its current form. New scholars such as Jules Martinez-Olivieri, Rodolfo Estrada, and Sammy Alfaro, are carrying the field in new directions, especially in

[76]Gonzalez, Justo. email message to author, September 1, 2015.
[77]Aponte and De la Torre, *Handbook of Latina/o Theologies*, 1.
[78]Delgado and Stefancic, *Critical Race,* 8,9.
[79]Valdes and Bender, *LatCrit*, 7.
[80]González, *Santa Biblia*, 31,57,77,91,103.

regard to the development of new Latinx Pentecostal identities and theologies of social and racial justice.

A central tenet of Latinx theology is teología en conjunto, or collaborative communal theology.[81] Latinx theologians assert that theological reflection should never be a lone ranger scholastic endeavor aimed at individualistic academic acclaim. Rather, theology is a communal endeavor which must always be rooted in the firsthand experience of the grassroots Latinx community itself. Teología en conjunto flows from the mutual dialogue of pastors, theologians, and lay parishioners. Since its inception, Latinx theology has been ecumenical – both Protestant and Catholic – because its progenitors understood the important value of ethnic solidarity beyond denominational lines. Moreover, the ultimate goal of Latinx theology is not abstract reflection upon God and the church, but orthopraxis, or right action, which transforms the world. Latinx theologians insist that, just as faith without works is dead, so is theology dead if it does not engender the social and cultural uplift of the entire Latinx community. As public religious discourse centered upon issues of social justice, Latinx theology is by nature public theology aimed at social transformation.

Latinx theology understands that all theology is contextual and recognizes with great sadness and anger that the Bible has been utilized to wrongly justify colonialism, slavery, and all manner of racial injustice. Latinx theologians challenge such historical misuses of the Bible by asserting that there is no such thing as an entirely "objective" interpretation of the Bible not informed by the cultural context of the interpreter. This is to say that all theologies, like all knowledge, are socially circumscribed.[82] This epistemological limitation, in turn, underscores the value and importance of cultural diversity for the theological task. If the church is conceived as the Body of Christ, then individuals and communities of different cultural backgrounds represent different parts of the Body. No one cultural group has a monopoly on theological understanding, just as no single part of the human body is self-sufficient. The discipline of theology is therefore dependent upon the cultural interdependence of people of every tribe, language and tongue in order to understand God, the Bible, and the problems of the world more fully.

In recognition of the value of cultural context in interpreting Scripture, Justo Gonzalez has introduced the concept of "reading the Bible in Spanish," or with "Hispanic eyes."[83] By this, he is not necessarily referring to the literal reading of the Bible in the Spanish language, but rather to the practice of reading Scripture in light of the distinct and diverse historical experiences of Latinx communities of the United States. "If it is true that we bring a particular perspective to history and to theology, then we must also bring a particular perspective to the interpretation of Scripture. And, once again, it may be that this perspective will prove useful not only to us but also to the church at large."[84] "Hispanic eyes," moreover, according to Gonzalez, "is the perspective of those who claim their Hispanic identity as part of their hermeneutical baggage, and also read the Scripture within the context of a commitment to the Latino struggle

[81]Aponte and De la Torre, *Handbook*, 7.
[82]Martell-Otero, Pérez, and Conde-Frazier, *Latina Evangélicas*, 2–3.
[83]Gonzalez, *Mañana*, 28.
[84]Ibid., 75.

to become all that God wants us and all of the world to be—in other words, the struggle for salvation/liberation."[85] "Reading the Bible in Spanish" has led many Latinx theologians to reflect upon on the social and ethnic marginality of the historical Jesus of Nazareth.

In order to reclaim Jesus of Nazareth from the sordid legacy of colonial theologies, Latinx theologians have framed the "Galilee principle" and the concept of "Christ outside the gate."[86] Latinx authors such as Virgilio Elizondo and Orlando Costas have reflected upon the theological significance of "Galilee" in the Gospel accounts. In books of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, we are told that Jesus was raised in Galilee, selected Galileans as his first disciples, and performed most of his public ministry in Galilee. According to Christian tradition, Jesus even told his disciples to meet him in Galilee after his death and resurrection. Roman Catholic theologian Virgilio Elizondo argues that the Galilean roots of Jesus point to God's preferential option for those on the margins of society. To use contemporary language, Galilee was the "hood" of Jesus' day and was a symbol of multiple rejection.[87] Galileans were mostly poor subsistence farmers and were colonized by the Romans. They were forced to grow extra crops for Roman tribute and temple taxes, and many lost their lands to large landholders due to unmanageable debt. Galileans lived in a multicultural borderlands region in the northern fringes of the Jewish community. They were multilingual and spoke with a distinctive accent that set them apart from their compatriots of the big city of Jerusalem which was the center of Jewish religious, economic, and political life. Moreover, Jesus was from Nazareth, a marginalized town within a marginalized region. In other words, if Jesus lived among us today, he would be Latinx.

Based upon his understanding of Galilee as a marginalized socio-geographic location in the biblical narrative, Elizondo articulates the "Galilee principle": What human beings reject, God chooses as his very own.[88] Offering a similar summation of Jesus' marginalized Galilean roots, Protestant theologian Orlando Costas wrote of Jesus as "jíbaro," a unique Puerto Rican term for peasant or country bumpkin.[89] Building upon the analyses of Elizondo and Costas, Loida Martell-Otero refers to him as "Jesus sato," or, Jesus the shunned mongrel or mutt: "Thus to refer to him as 'Jesús sato' is to acknowledge that Jesus is a historical peripherally placed person who faces the struggles of his very humanity in the midst of a colonized and peripherally placed people."[90] Unlike traditional Christologies, or theologies of Jesus, which portray idealized saintly and sanitized pictures of Jesus as emotionally aloof, Jesus sato, as God incarnate, weeps, gets angry, chastises and tires.

Building upon the theme of the marginality of Christ, Puerto Rican missiologist Orlando Costas argued that Christ not only lived his life in the metaphorical margins of Galilee, but also suffered "outside the gate" of the institutional powers of Jerusalem.[91] As described in the book of Hebrews:

[85]Gonzalez, *Santa Biblia,* 28–29.
[86]Elizondo, *Galilean Journey*. Costas, *Christ Outside the Gate*.
[87]Elizondo, *Galilean Journey*, 91, 50–53.
[88]Ibid., 91.
[89]Martell-Otero, Pérez, and Conde-Frazier, *Latina Evangélicas*, 37.
[90]Ibid., 37.
[91]Costas, *Christ Outside the Gate*, 13, 188, 189.

> Therefore Jesus also suffered outside the city gate in order to sanctify the people by his own blood. 13 Let us then go to him outside the camp and bear the abuse he endured. 14 For here we have no lasting city, but we are looking for the city that is to come. Hebrews 13: 12–14

For Costas, Christ's suffering outside the city gate of Jerusalem signifies God's close identification with all who are disenfranchised and cast aside by society, such as the Latinx community of the United States. "Jesus Christ is today one with the outcast and oppressed of the earth. Wherever there is oppression, there is the Spirit of Christ incarnated in the experience of the oppressed; there is God contextualized in the present history of the nonpersons of society."[92] In order to be faithful to Jesus, Christians must "go to him outside the camp," outside the gates of the city and all its institutional power.[93] In the twenty-first century, Jesus continues to reside among all those who are excluded from systems and institutions of power, and he sides with them in their oppression. In order to truly know God then, requires a relinquishment of privilege and power and radical solidarity with all on the literal and figurative margins of society – all of those "outside the gate."

Building upon these notions of Christ as Liberator, and in strong resonance with Latina feminist studies, Latina theologians have developed theology which challenges Latin American patriarchy and supports the active leadership of female clergy. Two branches of Latina feminist theology include Mujerista theology and Latina Evangelica theology. Roman Catholic theologian Ada María Isasi-Díaz developed the term mujerista to describe a person who makes a preferential option for Latina women and their struggle for liberation.[94] According to Mujerista theology, God takes the side of women in their oppression. Moreover, Mujeristas celebrate the fact that women, equally and uniquely, reflect the image of God, and are therefore equal to men in both the spiritual and temporal realms. Mujerista theology calls out the oppressive patriarchal and racist structures that oppress Latinas, and it promotes the process of liberation from internalized oppression.[95] In the words of path-breaking mujerista theologian Ada María Isasi-Díaz:

> In the mujerista God revindicates the divine image and likeness of women. The mujerista is called to gestate new women and men: a strong people. Mujeristas are anointed by God as servants, prophets and witnesses of redemption. Mujeristas will echo God's reconciling love; their song will be a two-edged sword, and they will proclaim the gospel of liberation.[96]

In their recent path-breaking book, *Latina Evangélicas: A Theological Survey from the Margins*, Loida Martell-Otero, Zaida Maldonado- Perez, and Elizabeth Conde-Frazier contemplate a distinct Latina evangelical identity and theology based on the perspective of Latina Protestants in the United States. Latina evangélica theology is distinguished by its triple emphasis on the importance of the Holy Spirit, soteriology, and Scripture.[97] According to evangélicas, the Holy Spirit empowers women and legitimizes their calling in the face of patriarchal and racist social and ecclesial structures. The Holy Spirit personally guides and empowers Latinas in the daily struggle of lo cotidiano [the quotidian] in the spaces of family, labor, church, and society. As a consequence,

[92]Ibid., 13.
[93]Ibid., 188, 189.
[94]Isasi-Diaz, *Mujerista*, 60.
[95]Ibid, 62–63.
[96]Isasi-Diaz. "Mujeristas: A Name of Our Own!" 560.
[97]Martell-Otero, Pérez, and Conde-Frazier, *Latina Evangélicas*, 30, 31, 35.

Jesus brings salvation in very concrete ways – socially, economically, and politically – and even in the smallest, but important details of daily life. For Latina evangélicas, salvation is holistic and Christianity therefore must be incarnated in the spaces of the everyday. Recognizing the feminine grammatical gender of "spirit" in the original Hebrew language of the Old Testament, Maldonado-Pérez even refers to the Holy Spirit as "she," and declares poetically,

> I love the Holy Spirit. She is like the wild child of the Trinity, anywhere and everywhere moving, calling forth, and stirring things up. She is wonderfully illusive yet also fully present. She is untamable, full of possibilities and creative potential. She is the salsa beat in our daily foxtrot and the un-dos-tres-bachata in our electric slide … She is life-giving breath, wind, and fire. She is the ruach elohim, the flaming divine pneuma that is always "going native" because she wants to be encountered by all … Filled, inspired, and moved by the Holy Spirit, evangélicas engage life from the perspective of the One who is able to move over chaos, nothingness, and death, speaking life into death bearing situations and being midwives to hope. The Holy Spirit emboldens us, even through the shadow of death, to fight the good fight on behalf of those gripped by despair.[98]

Conclusion

Although the Brown Church and Brown Theology have served as the inspiration for widescale social change in Latin America and the United States over the past five hundred years, both have been largely ignored by scholars of public theology, Chicanx/Latinx Studies, CRT, and LatCrit.

Chicano civil rights icon César Chávez, and Luis Olivares, the lesser known grassroots leader of the Los Angeles-based Sanctuary Movement, serve as two examples of public theologians who fused Mexican American Catholic spirituality, Catholic social teachings, and community organizing principles to path-breaking racial justice avail. Building upon the examples of these leaders of the Brown Church, Latinx theology has developed over the past three decades in thematic and justice concert with Chicanx/Latinx Studies, Critical Race Theory, and LatCrit. Unfortunately, Brown Theologians have held little meaningful conversation with CRT and Ethnic Studies scholars, and vice versa. In the words of Latina religious studies scholar Michelle A. González states, "Latino/a theology's emphasis on the theological academy as the primary, and often exclusive conversation partner limits its scope. It is curious that Latino/a theologians do not enter into dialogue with area studies, ethnic studies, critical race theory, and the social sciences in a more explicit manner to enrich their discussions of Latino/a identity and faith life."[99]

It is my contention that Brown Theology has much potential to serve as a synergistic intellectual partner for Chicanx/Latinx Studies, Critical Race Theory (CRT), and Latinx Critical Race Theory (LatCrit). Brown Theology deconstructs the faulty religious assumptions which gave rise to legal constructions of race and subsequent structures of racial inequality in the U.S., replaces them with liberatory theological frameworks, and unearths the poignant but forgotten history of religious justice embodied by the Brown Church for more than five centuries. In the successful example of Dolores Huerta, Cesar Chavez, and others, Brown Theology may also be utilized for the practical

[98]Ibid, 43, 44, 46–47.
[99]González, *A Critical Introduction to Religion in the Americas*, 91.

purpose of promoting conscientization, community organizing, and social engagement among the tens of millions from grassroots Latinx communities for whom religion remains important.

As a tangible example of the potential of Brown Theology to serve as synergistic partner with Chicanx/Latinx Studies and Critical Race Theory, I share the example of my book, *Brown Church*, and how it has sparked a larger conversation about the role of religion and ecumenical Christianity within Chicanx/Latinx Studies. Utilizing the CRT framework of community cultural wealth, I argue in *Brown Church* that the study of Christianity is important to the latter fields because, for better and for worse, Christianity has played a central role in Latin America and among U.S. Latinx communities for centuries. On the positive front, Christianity has served as a hallmark of Latinx community cultural wealth and as the basis for five centuries of social justice through the Brown Church. Despite the critical role played by Christianity as a source of community cultural wealth and spiritual capital for diverse Latinx communities over the centuries, the study of Christianity has been largely overlooked in the established literature of Chicanx/Latinx Studies. In response to the publication of *Brown Church*, and as a meaningful response to the critique which it presented, I was invited to serve as editor of a special essay collection on Christianity for the flagship journal of Chicanx Studies, *Aztlan: A Journal of Chicano Studies*. This essay collection, which I co-edited with Jacqueline Hidalgo and David Flores, was entitled, "Dossier: Rethinking the Role of Religion in Latinx and Chicanx Studies."[100] For the dossier we invited eight noted multi-disciplinary scholars from the fields of critical race theory, education, theology, history, literature, and the arts, to reflect upon the following questions:

1. Why has Christianity (ecumenical) been left out as a topic of research and of instruction?
2. What are the consequences of such an omission?
3. What would it look like to imagine the integration of religion/Christianity as a topic of research and instruction in the field?

The result was a fertile and path-breaking conversation in which contributors shared about their personal experiences of negotiating and attempting to bridge the often different worlds of Chicanx studies, religious studies, theological studies, humanities, and the social sciences. One especially notable essay was contributed by Daniel Solórzano, the founder of the field of critical race theory in education. For the first time in his storied academic career of more than 40 years, in this essay, Solórzano narrates how Catholic social teaching shaped his own activism and scholarship:

> I was born and baptized a Catholic in 1949, and my journey with the Church is bound up with my family, community, educational, and activist histories … Through the everyday rituals and beliefs of the Catholic Church, I was reminded in scripture, stories, and deeds that you must give yourself in service to others less fortunate … For me, CST [Catholic Social Teaching] embodies the essential elements of my Catholic faith: the preferential option for the poor and the vulnerable and the commitment to social and racial justice.[101]

[100]"Dossier: Rethinking the Role of Religion in Latinx and Chicanx Studies," eds. Robert Chao Romero, Jacqueline M. Hidalgo, and David Flores, 129–241.
[101]Ibid. Solórzano. "My Journey from Catholic Social Teaching."

In the remainder of his essay, Solórzano explores a definition of what he calls, "CRT in the Church." "I now define CRT in the Church as an analytical framework that accounts for the sin of racism in the Church (and society) and that works toward identifying and challenging racism in the Church as steps toward a larger goal of identifying and challenging all forms of subordination inside and outside the Church."[102] Solórzano's essay and theoretical construction of CRT in the Church, together with the *Aztlan* dossier as a whole, serve as tangible evidence of the potential of Brown Theology to serve as synergistic partner with Chicanx/Latinx Studies and Critical Race Theory.

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[102]Ibid., 153.

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